LAW & JUDICIARY | Rebooting Democracy

DEMOCRACY'S DISCONTENT: Ideas of justice. Why we are so divided. And how to fix it

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HUBRIS OF THE ELITE

The hubris of a liberal, well-educated elite anchored in meritocracy; the exclusion and resentment of the masses; a need for identity, belonging and community; and the politics of a common good—can these ideas explain the great political churning of our times? To Michael Sandel, well-known as a 'rockstar' political philosopher who can fill stadiums and get millions of views online for his debates, all of this has come into play over the past 40 years in democracies across the world, especially so in his home country, the USA. First among these, he theorises, is that people who presided over the market-driven version of globalisation which argued for the unfettered flow of goods, capital and people across borders, missed something important—the human need for belonging, community and national identities. Fuelling the eventual backlash against the elites was a certain hubris—the 'tyranny of merit' which, as Sandel describes it, is the tendency of the successful 'to inhale too deeply of their own success', forgetting the luck and good fortune that helped them on their way and 'looking down on those who struggle'.

Central to rebuilding a political discourse that has hollowed out into shouting matches is 'one of the great civic virtues of our time'—listening. ■

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- Liberal elites and mainstream political parties who governed over 40-50 years missed the rising anger and resentment of those who felt excluded
- There are two dimensions to the backlash—one, a sense of being looked down upon by well-educated, hubristic elites; alongside this, the neglect of the need for identity, belonging and community which opened a void that was filled by hypernationalists
- The question of justice cannot really be separated from the politics of memory



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> **I think democracy is in danger, under threat... in many countries around the world, which is not to say that democracy is without sources of rejuvenation**
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> **We can't do without a politics of the common good even though it can be weaponised. Likewise, we can't do without a politics of memory even though it can harden into dangerous terms**